LODESTAR USER GUIDE · 121 SQN

Master Planner

Planning the squadron's flights, squadron events and flight codes

DRAFT · NOT FOR ISSUE · 6 NOVEMBER 2026

Who this guide is for

This guide is for the person who keeps the squadron's flight programme: the flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, flight codes and the Crew Matrix.

In this guide

Part 1 Getting started: how LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved.

Part 2 Master Planner: planning the squadron's flights, squadron events and flight codes.

Start with **Part 1, Getting started**. The contents on the next page give the page of every section. Every page in the dashboard also has its own help: press the **?** button at the right end of the tab bar.

LODESTAR · 121 SQN · **Master Planner guide** · Dated 6 November 2026 · For dashboard version z196 (BETA) · Screenshots use demo data only: the names, callsigns and flights are made up.

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PART 1

Getting started

How LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved

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1.1 What LODESTAR is

LODESTAR is the squadron's daily flying and ops planner. It replaces copying plans by hand between the department Excel files and the Ops Room. It has two pieces:

- **Eight Excel files** in the SharePoint folder **Program**. They hold all the data. They have no macros and still open normally in Excel.
- **The dashboard**, one web page in the same folder. It opens the Excel files, shows them as planners, calendars and boards, and saves your changes back into them.

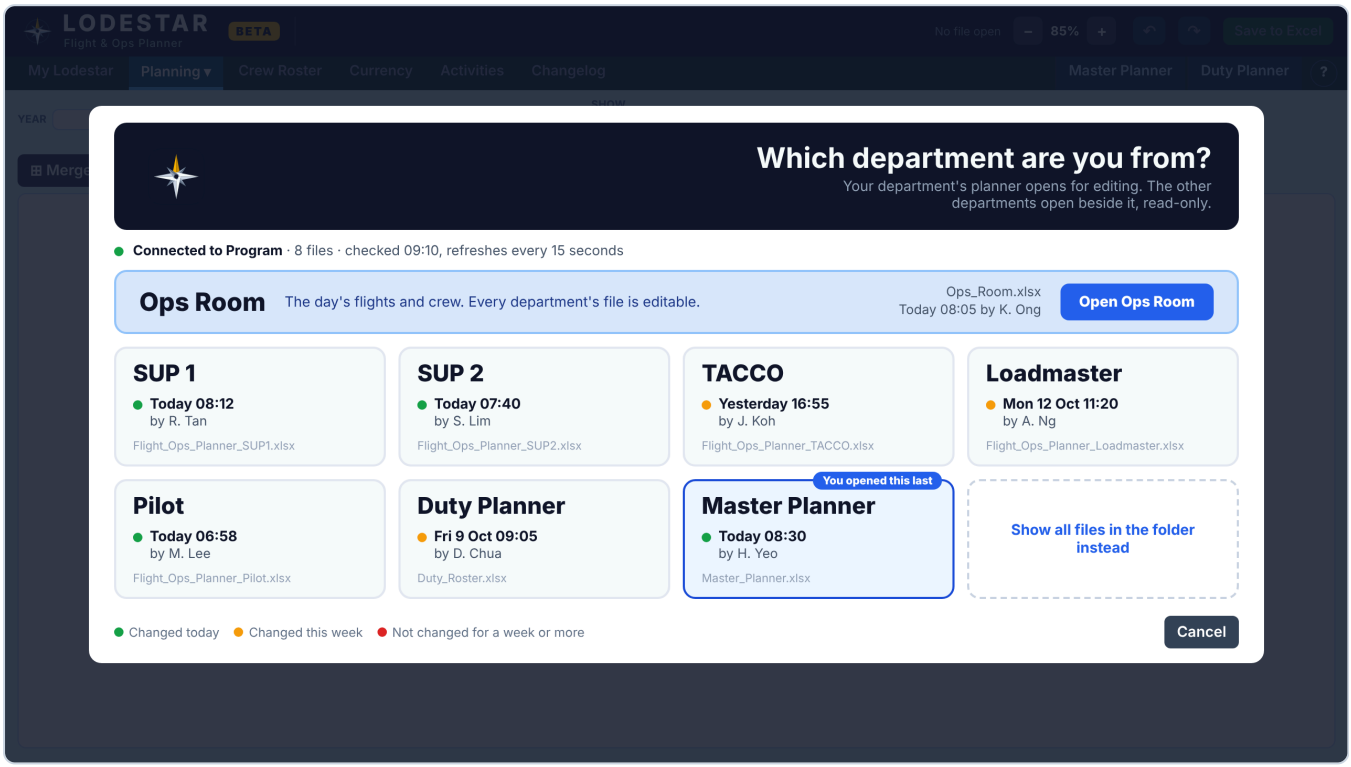
File	What it holds
Flight_Ops_Planner_SUP1, _SUP2, _TACCO, _Loadmaster, _Pilot	One file per department: the crew list, each person's plan for every day (AM, PM, NIGHT and a whole-day WD row), currency, syllabus and the month totals.
Master_Planner	The squadron's flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, flight codes and the Crew Matrix. It is the one true list of flights.
Duty_Roster	Who does BDO on each day, and which department does SDO on each day.
Ops_Room	The day board: tails, seats, ATD and ATA, flown or cancelled, Ops Adds, flying restrictions, down-chits and the ATOM currency export.

HOW THE PLAN FLOWS

The **Master Planner** plans the flights. Each **department** copies its flights into its own planner and puts its people on them. The **Duty Planner** hands out BDO and SDO days, and each department copies its days too. The **Ops Room** reads all of it and fills the seats on the day's board by itself. Nobody has to retype anything.

1.2 Opening LODESTAR

1. Open the SharePoint folder **Program** and open the LODESTAR dashboard file in Edge.
2. The screen **"Which department are you from?"** appears. Each card shows when its file last changed and who changed it: green is today, amber is this week, red is a week or more ago.
3. Click your own card. Your file opens **for editing** and the other files open beside it **to view only**, so you can see the rest of the squadron.



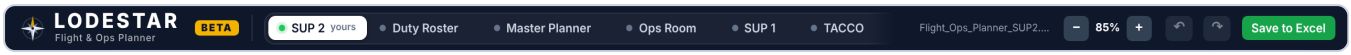
The department screen. The card you opened last is marked "You opened this last".

- The dashboard remembers your choice in this browser. To pick another card, click the **LODESTAR** logo at the top left.
- **⟳ Refresh** or F5 reads the latest files again and keeps you where you are.
- On SharePoint the dashboard looks for changes from other people every 15 seconds and shows them without you doing anything.

> **DASHBOARD AND FILES GO TOGETHER**
>
> The dashboard and the Excel files are made as a matched set. If a yellow bar says a file uses an **older layout** or is **newer than the dashboard**, tell the LODESTAR maintainer. Do not keep planning in a mixed set.

1.3 The screen

Top bar



The top bar.

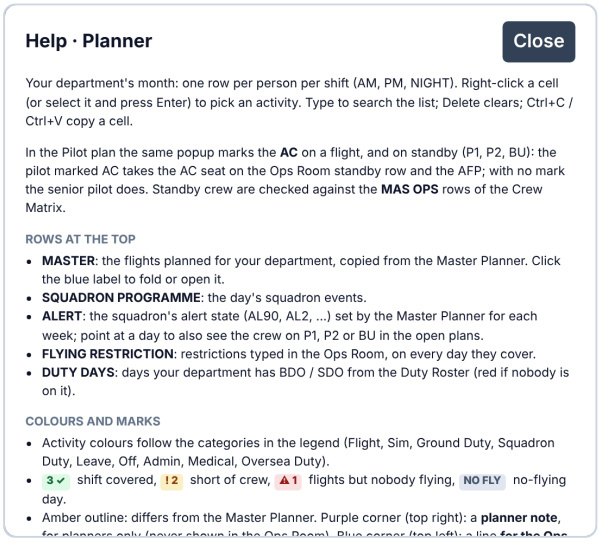
- **The file pills** list the open files. Yours is white and marked **yours**. A grey dot means view only.
- **− 100% +** zooms the whole page. Use it to fit the planner on a small screen.
- ↶ ↷ undo and redo.
- **Save to Excel** saves now. It turns bright green when there is something to save.

Tab bar



The tab bar. The padlock on Master Planner means you can look but not change it.

Tab	What it is
My Lodestar	Your own page: today's flight, your month, your currency and what changed. View only.
Planning ▾	Planner (the month plan), Overview, Syllabus Tracking and Miscellaneous Notes (the Department Planner guide).
Crew Roster, Currency, Activities	Your department's crew list, currency checks and activity list (the Department Planner guide).
Changelog	Every saved change, with who and when (section 1.4).
Ops Room	The day board (the Ops Room guide). Departments see it view only.
Master Planner ▾	The squadron calendar, Flight Codes and Crew Matrix (Part 2).
Duty Planner	BDO and SDO (the Department Planner guide).
?	Help for the page you are on, with the meaning of its colours.



The help (?) for the Planner.

1.4 Saving, undo and the Changelog

Saving

- **On SharePoint your work saves by itself** a few seconds after each change. `Save to Excel` saves at once.
- Only the cells you changed are written. The rest of the file, including its formulas and drop-downs, is left alone. If someone else saved the same file in the meantime, their changes are kept and yours are added on top.
- If you close the tab with unsaved changes, the browser asks you to confirm.

Undo and redo

`↶` and `↷`, or **Ctrl+Z** and **Ctrl+Y**, undo and redo your recent changes (up to 40 steps).

Changelog

Every save is written to a **Change Log** sheet in the file itself: when, who, what changed in words, and the value before and after. The `Changelog` tab shows the log of your own file, the Master Planner and the Ops Room. You can filter by person, file, day or text, and hover over a line to see the exact sheet and cell. Lines older than 90 days are dropped; SharePoint's version history keeps older copies of the file.

1.5 Who can change what

You opened	You can change	You can see
Your department	Your department's plan, Crew Roster, Currency, Activities, Syllabus and Notes.	Every other file, view only.
Master Planner	Flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, Flight Codes and the Crew Matrix.	Every other file, view only.
Duty Roster	The BDO and SDO roster and the duty crew lists.	Every other file, view only.
Ops Room	The day board. It can also up-chit a person in a department file.	Every file.

On SharePoint this also follows the folder's edit rights. If you have no edit rights on a file, you cannot save it, even if you picked its card.

> **EXCEL STILL WORKS**
>
> You can open any of the files in desktop Excel to read or print them. Prefer the dashboard for changes: it keeps the copies between files in step. If you do edit in Excel, close the file before others save from the dashboard.

1.6 Common questions

Question	Answer
Everything is locked (🔒) and I cannot click.	You opened another department's card. Click the LODESTAR logo and pick your own.
I can't see a change someone just made.	Wait 15 seconds, or press ⟳ Refresh (F5).
A yellow bar says "older layout".	The files and the dashboard don't match. Tell the LODESTAR maintainer.
Save to Excel stays green.	The save did not go through. Check you are still signed in to SharePoint and have edit rights, then press it again.
The page is too big for my screen.	Use − in the top bar to zoom out.

PART 2

Master Planner

Planning the squadron's flights, squadron events and flight codes

The Master Planner is the one list of flights for 121 SQN. Every department copies its flights from it, the Ops Room builds the day's board from it, and crew see it on their own pages. Department planners can look at the calendar but cannot change it.

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QS Quick start

1. **Open the dashboard** and pick **Master Planner** on the department screen. The calendar opens with your file ready to edit.
2. **Pick the month** in the **MONTH** box at the top left, and **click a day**. The day opens in a panel on the right.
3. **Press** **+ Add flight**, pick or type the **flight code** and type the **time as a range**, for example **0830-1030**. The start time decides the shift and the range gives the planned hours.
4. **Check the crew tags** (P, L, T, S1, S2). They come from the flight code. Click one to change it for this flight only.
5. **For a running change**, type 2 or 3 in the **Sorties** box. Leave it blank for a normal flight.
6. **Mark days with no flying** with the **Day status** box, and add **squadron events** with **+ Add squadron event** (always choose ALL or the tags).
7. **Let it save.** Departments see the change within about 15 seconds and copy it into their planners.

2.1 What the Master Planner holds

- **Flights:** every planned flight of the year, with its date, time, flight code, sorties, crew tags and a comment.
- **Day status:** which days have no flying, and why.
- **Squadron events:** ground events for the squadron, such as meetings, ceremonies and lectures.
- **Alert states:** the squadron's alert state for each week (AL90, AL2...).
- **Flight codes:** the one list of flight codes the squadron uses.
- **Crew Matrix:** the lowest CAT allowed in each seat on a mission.

Where your plan goes

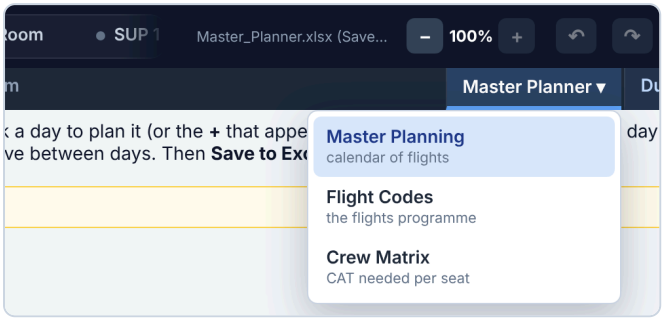
Who	What they get
Department planners	Their flights and squadron events on the MASTER and SQUADRON PROGRAMME rows, after they press the copy button. A department only gets a flight if its crew tags include it. New flight codes reach their Activities list by themselves the next time they save.
Ops Room	The day's flight board, one row per sortie, with the seats filled from the department plans. No-flying days and flying restrictions show there too.
Crew	Their flights on My Lodestar.
Outside offices	A clean Excel copy of the flights and planned hours, made with **Export...** (section 2.12).

Words used in this part

Word	Meaning
Flight code	The short name of a kind of flight, for example FLT-2.0, NVG-2.0 or MAS TRG. Each code has a description, default crew and a Mission Type.
Shift	AM, PM or NIGHT. The start time decides it: before 1200H is AM, before 1800H is PM, later is NIGHT.
Crew tags	**P** Pilot, **L** Loadmaster, **T** TACCO, **S1** SUP 1, **S2** SUP 2. On a flight, no tags means every department.
Sorties	How many sorties one flight is split into. A normal flight is 1. A running change is 2 or 3.
Planned hours	Worked out from the flight's time range. 0830H-1030H is 2.0 hours. ATOM stays the record of the hours actually flown.

2.2 Opening the Master Planner

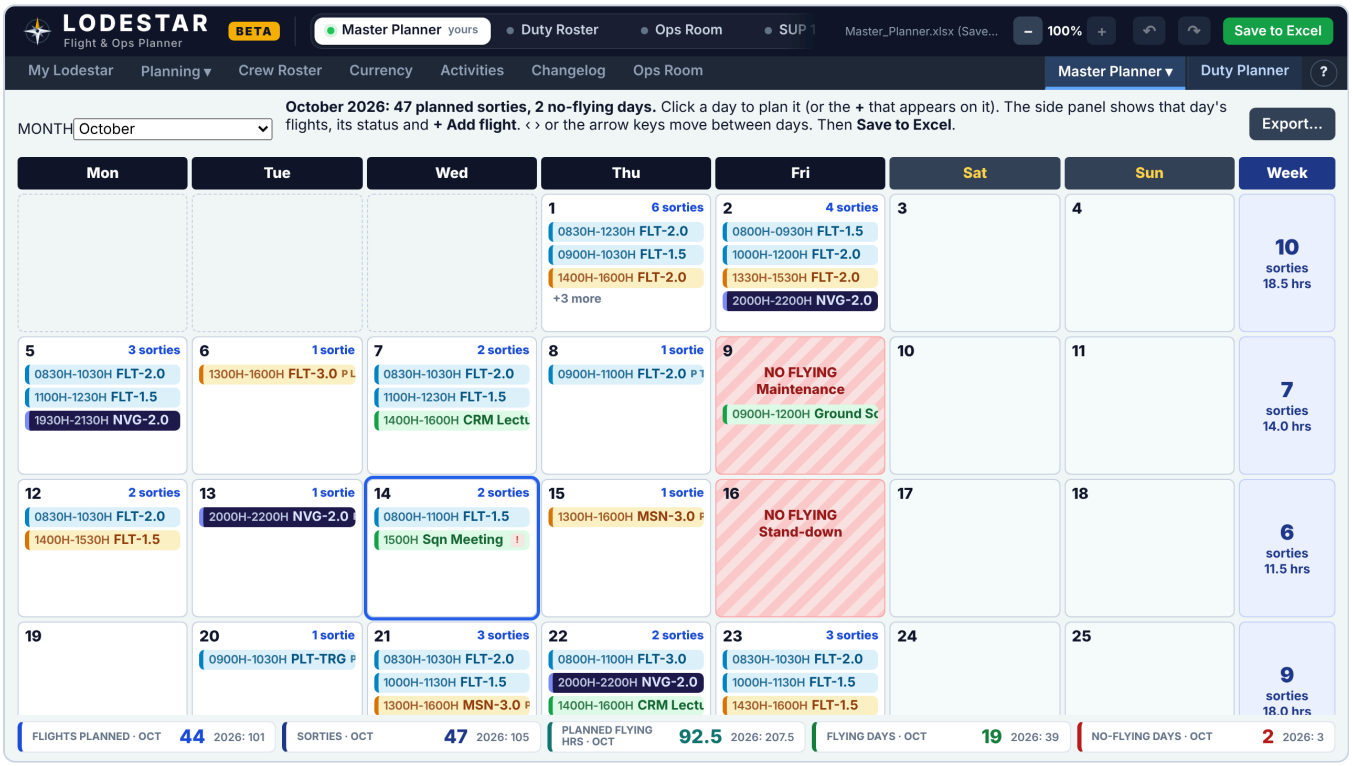
Pick **Master Planner** on the department screen (Part 1). The calendar is under the **Master Planner ▾** tab at the right of the tab bar, which has three pages:



The Master Planner menu.

- **Master Planning:** the calendar of flights. This is where you spend most of your time.
- **Flight Codes:** the list of flight codes (section 2.10).
- **Crew Matrix:** the CAT each seat needs on a mission (section 2.11).

2.3 Reading the calendar

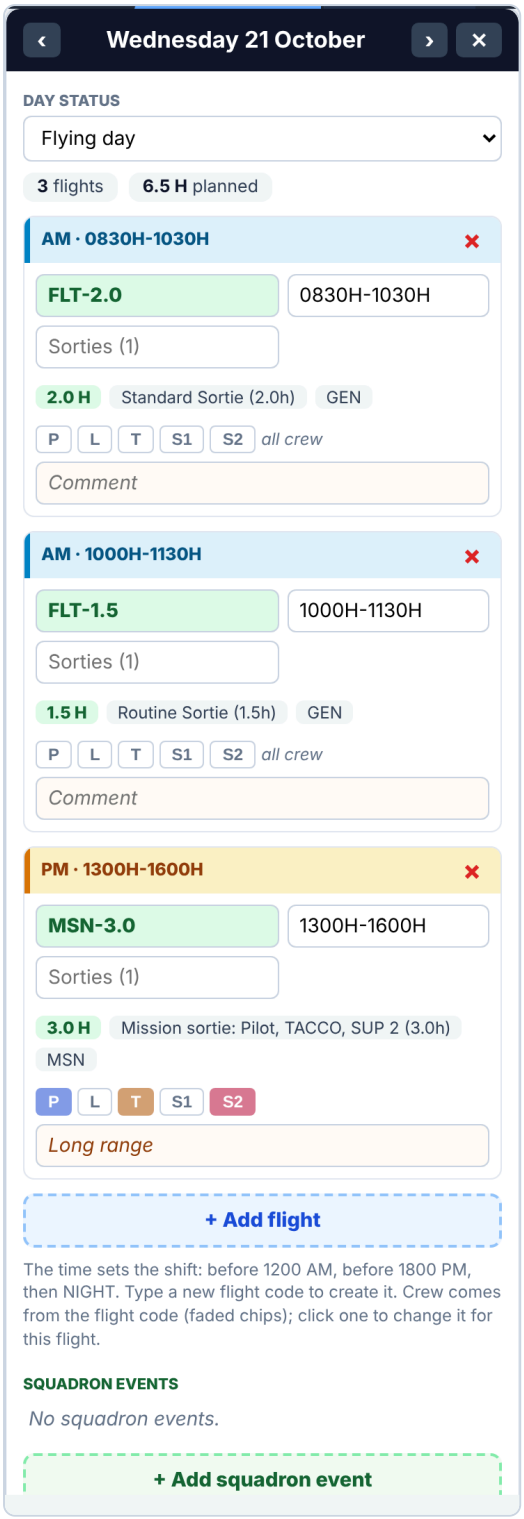


Master Planning, October. Each day lists its flights and squadron events. The Week column adds up the week.

What you see	What it means
0830H-1030H FLT-2.0 PM NIGHT	A flight: its time range and flight code, in its shift colour. Crew tags follow when the flight has its own crew.
1500H Sqn Meeting	A squadron event. A red **!** on it means nobody was chosen to attend (section 2.7).
NO FLYING · Maintenance	A no-flying day and its reason (section 2.6).
RESTRICTION	A flying restriction covers this day (section 2.9).
"3 sorties", "+3 more", blue outline	Sorties planned that day; more items than fit (click the day); today.

The strip along the bottom shows this month and the whole year: flights planned, sorties, planned flying hours, flying days and no-flying days. Flights on a no-flying day are not counted. Hover over a chip to see its full details.

2.4 Planning a day



The day panel: Day status, the day's flights, + Add flight and Squadron events.

Click a day. It opens in a panel on the right. ‹ › or the arrow keys move a day; ✕ or Esc closes it.

Add a flight

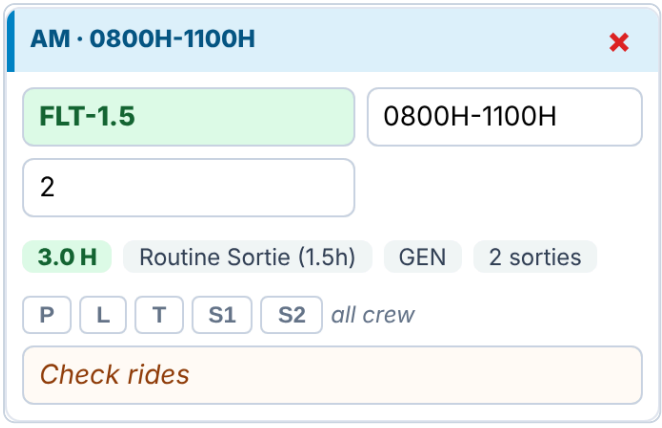
1. Press **+ Add flight**.
2. **Flight code:** pick from the list, or type it. Capitals and spaces do not matter. A code that is not on the list starts a new code (section 2.5).
3. **Time:** type the range, for example **0830-1030**. It is saved as 0830H-1030H, and the flight moves to the right shift by itself.
4. **Sorties:** leave blank for a normal flight.
5. **Crew:** check the tags.
6. **Comment:** optional, for example "Long range". Departments see it.

To remove a flight, press the red ✕ in its header.

Times and planned hours

- **2200-0100** ends the next day and is 3.0 hours.
- **Only a start time** counts as 0 hours and shows a red **No end time** chip.
- 0 hours or over 12 hours shows a red **Check time** chip.

Running changes (Sorties)



A flight in the panel. The green chip is the planned hours from the time range.

A running change is **one flight** with **one time range covering the whole thing** and 2 or 3 in the **Sorties** box. Do not enter it as two flights.

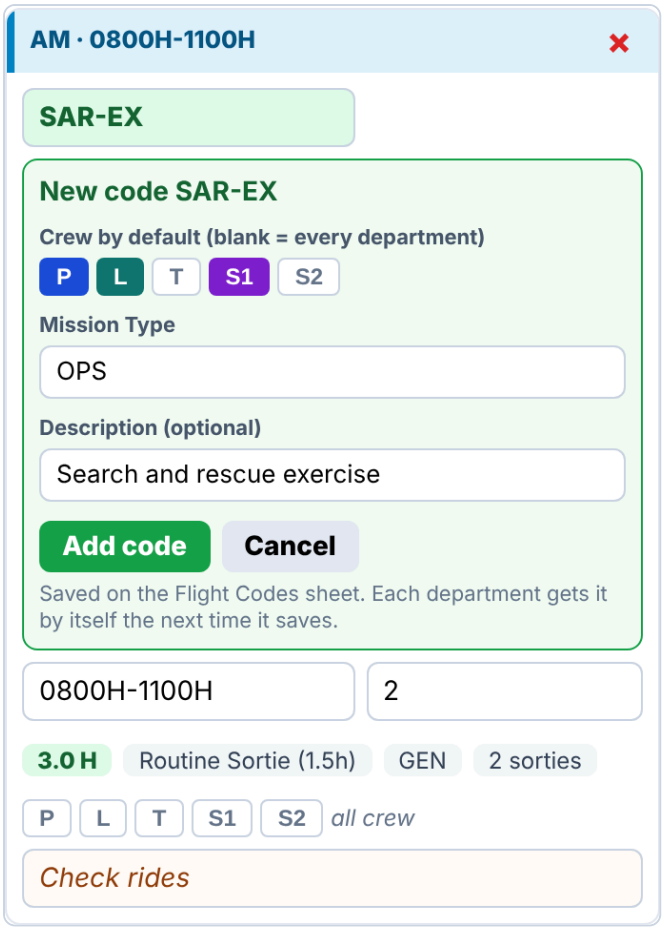
- The time is split evenly: 1000H-1300H with 2 sorties is two flights of 1.5 hours, **Flight 1/2** and **Flight 2/2**.
- The Ops Room shows one row per sortie. The departments choose who is crew or Pax on each one.
- A formation (two aircraft at once) is entered as two flights.

Crew tags

- **Faded tags** come from the flight code's default crew. "all crew" means the code has no default, so every department flies.
- **Click a tag** to switch it on or off for **this flight only**. The tags then show in colour.
- A department only gets the flight if its tag is on (or no tag is on).

> **TIP**
>
> Set the usual crew once on the flight code (section 2.10), and only change tags on the odd flight that differs.

2.5 Adding a new flight code

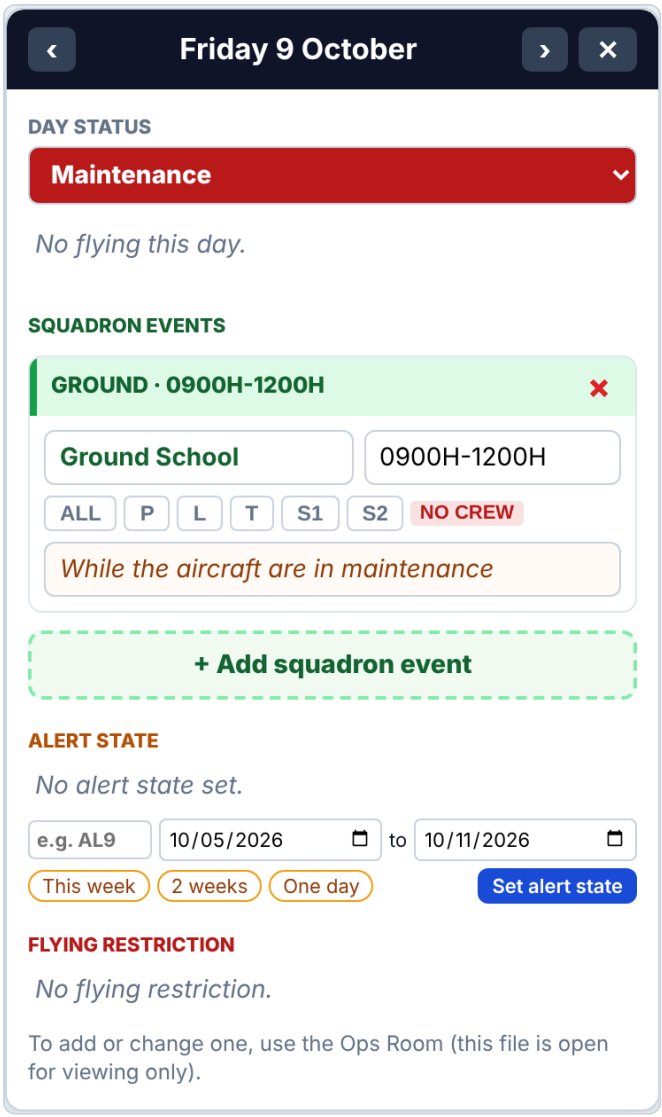


Typing a code that is not on the list opens the green New code panel.

1. Type the new code in a flight's code box and press Tab.
2. In the green **New code** panel choose the **crew by default**, the **Mission Type** (for example GEN, OPS or MAS TRG) and a description.
3. Press **Add code**.

Hours come from the time range, so one code covers every length of the same kind of flight: one **MAS** code can replace MAS3, MAS4 and MAS6.

2.6 No-flying days



A day set to Maintenance.

Use the **Day status** box at the top of the day panel. Choose a reason such as **Maintenance**, **Stand-down** or **Public Holiday**. The calendar day is striped with the reason.

- Choose **Flying day** to undo it.
- Flights already on that day are kept but greyed out. They are not counted and do not reach the departments or the Ops Room. Remove them if they are cancelled for good.
- Squadron events still work on a no-flying day.

2.7 Squadron events

Ground events for the squadron: meetings, ceremonies, lectures, sports. They show as green chips on the calendar and on each department's SQUADRON PROGRAMME row.

1. Press **+ Add squadron event** in the day panel.
2. Type or pick the **activity** and the **time**.
3. Choose who attends: **ALL**, or the crew tags of the departments that attend.
4. Add a comment if useful, such as the place.

> **ALWAYS CHOOSE WHO ATTENDS**
>
> A new event starts with nobody chosen and shows a red **NO CREW**. Unlike a flight, an event with no tags does **not** mean everyone: no department gets it until you pick ALL or the tags.

2.8 Alert state

The squadron's alert state changes from week to week (for example AL90 one week, AL2 the next). You set it in the **Alert state** section of the day panel:

1. Click any day in the week.
2. Type the level, or pick AL2 or AL90.
3. Check **From** and **To**. They start as that week, Monday to Sunday. **This week**, **2 weeks** and **One day** fill them for you.
4. Press **Set alert state**. × removes it.

A single day set inside a week overrides the week for that day. Departments see the state on their ALERT row.

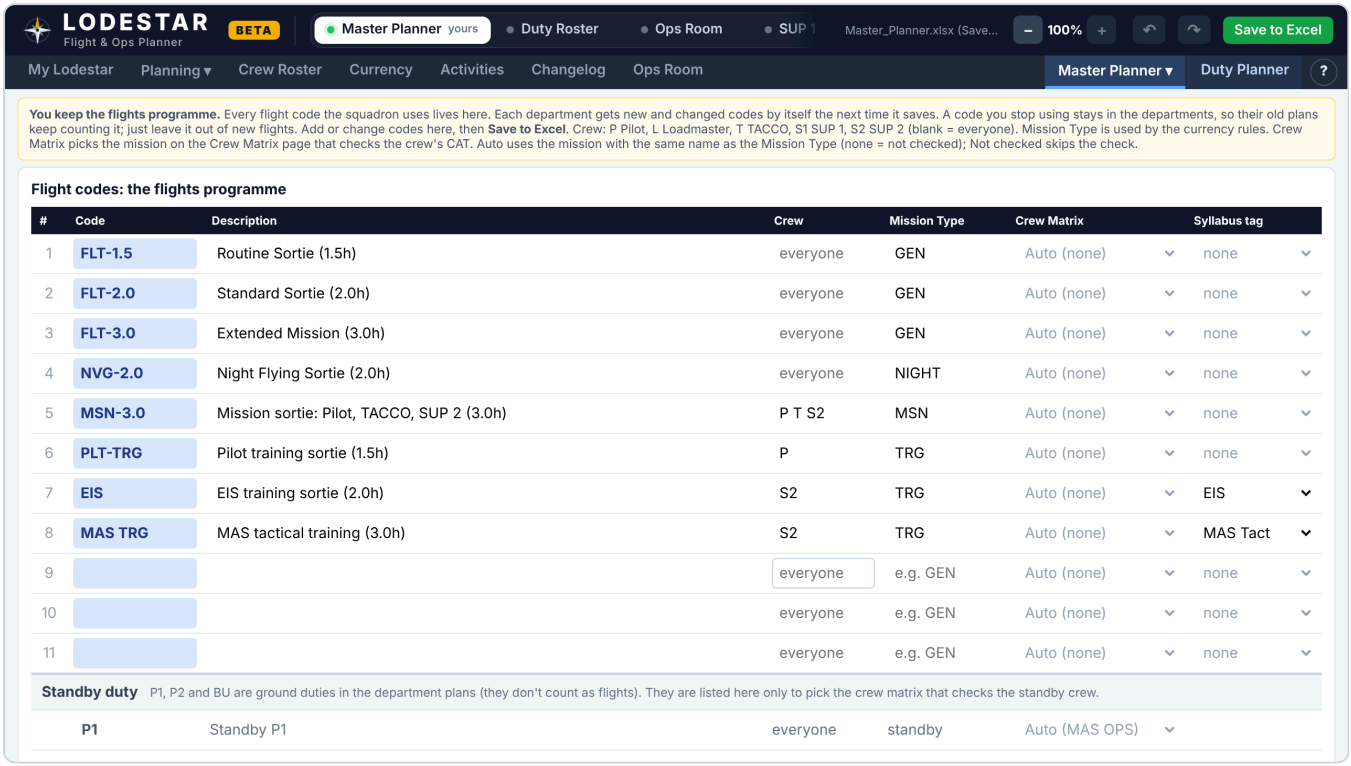
2.9 Flying restrictions

A flying restriction is a short notice for a range of dates, for example "No low flying in Area Echo". It shows as a red banner on the Ops Room, on the departments' FLYING RESTRICTION row, and as a **RESTRICTION** tag on the calendar.

- Restrictions are kept in the Ops Room file, so they are **added and changed in the Ops Room** (**+ Restriction**, the Ops Room guide).
- The day panel lists the day's restrictions. If you also have edit rights on the Ops Room file, you can add, change and remove them there.

2.10 The Flight Codes page

Master Planner ▾ → **Flight Codes**. Every flight code the squadron uses, one per row.



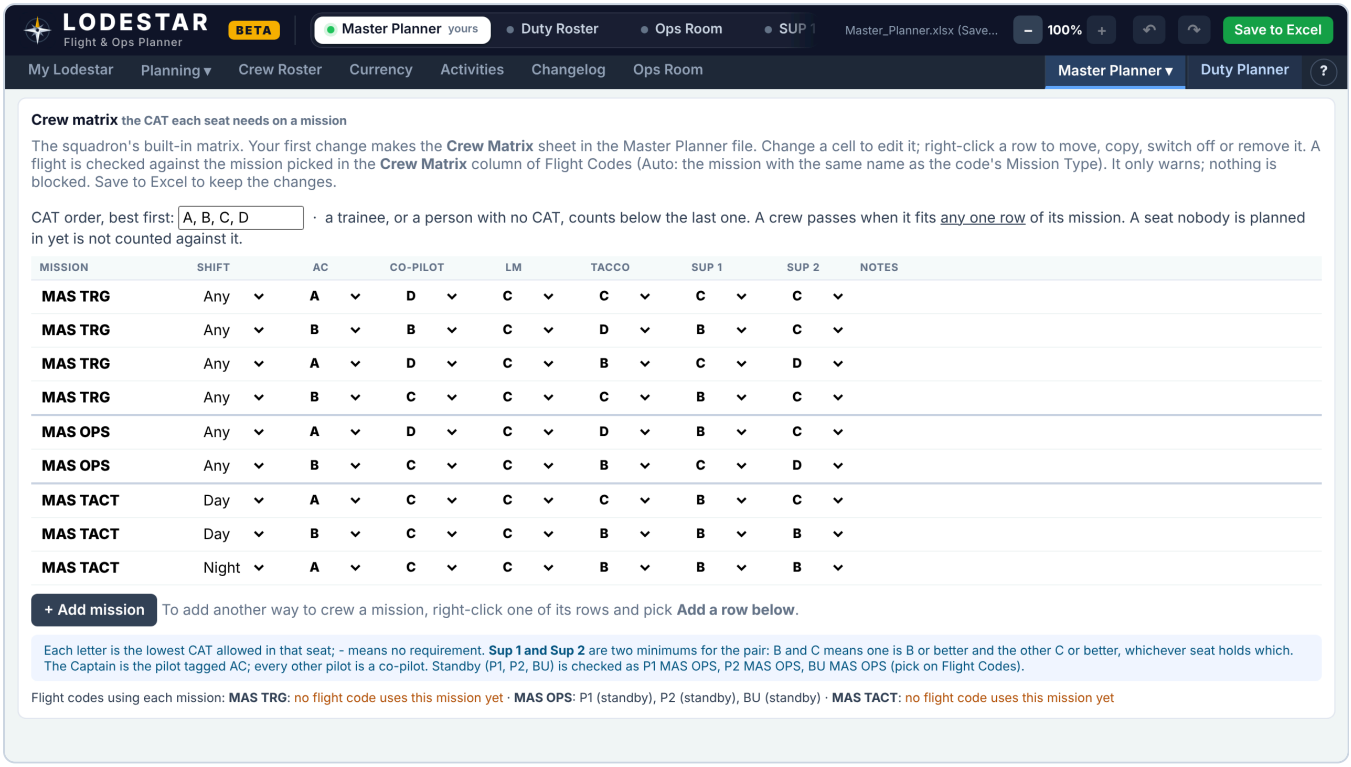
The Flight Codes page.

Column	What to type
Code	The short name used on the calendar. Keep each code unique.
Description	A plain description. Departments see it in their planner.
Crew	The default crew tags, for example **P T S2**. Blank means every department.
Mission Type	For example GEN, OPS or MAS TRG. Used by the currency rules and, by default, the Crew Matrix.
Crew Matrix	Which Crew Matrix mission checks this code. **Auto** uses the mission with the same name as the Mission Type; **Not checked** switches the check off.
Syllabus tag	Optional. Picks the syllabus track the departments are offered for this code.

- **Renaming a code:** you are asked whether to change the flights that use it.
- **Right-click a code** to **switch it off** (kept, greyed with OFF; not offered for new flights; flights already planned keep it and still count) or **remove** it (only when no flight this year uses it).
- The **Standby duty** block at the bottom sets which Crew Matrix mission checks P1, P2 and BU (normally MAS OPS).

2.11 The Crew Matrix

Master Planner ▾ → **Crew Matrix**. The lowest CAT allowed in each seat (AC, Co-pilot, LM, TACCO, SUP 1, SUP 2) for each mission.



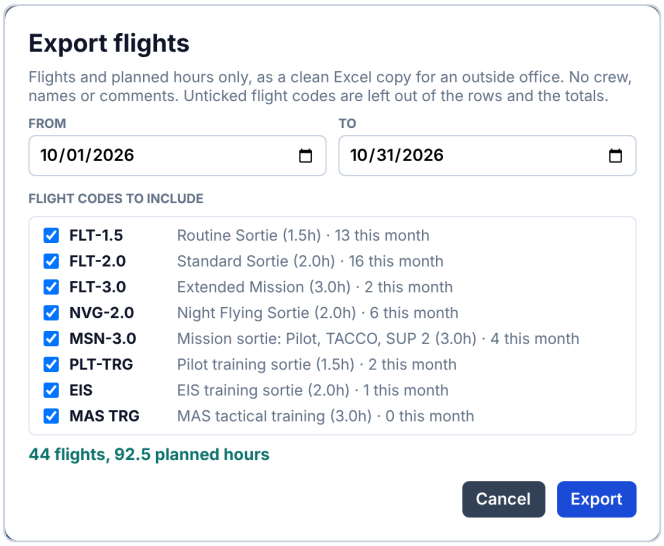
The Crew Matrix page.

- A flight is checked against the mission chosen for its flight code (section 2.10). Standby (P1, P2, BU) is checked as MAS OPS.
- A crew passes when it fits **any one row** of its mission. Seats nobody is planned in yet are not counted.
- When the planned crew fits no row, the flight card, the department planners and the Ops Room show a **CREW MATRIX** warning. **It only warns** and never blocks a plan.

Changing the matrix

- Click a cell to change the letter. **+ Add mission** adds a mission.
- Right-click a row to move it, add a copy below, switch it off (kept, not checked) or remove it.
- Rows that cannot be used are shown red with the reason.

2.12 Exporting the programme



The Export dialog.

Export... at the top right of Master Planning gives an outside office a clean Excel copy of the flight programme.

1. Choose the dates in **From** and **To**.
2. Untick any flight code to leave it out of the rows and the totals. Your ticks are remembered.
3. Press **Export**. An Excel file downloads.

The file has one **Calendar** sheet: each month as a calendar with every flight and its hours, the day and week totals, no-flying days with their reason, and a month total. It prints on landscape A4, one page wide.

> **NEVER EXPORTED**
>
> No crew, names, callsigns or comments. Only dates, times, flight codes and planned hours.

2.13 Who sees your changes

Who	When
Anyone with the dashboard open	Within about 15 seconds of your save.
Department planners	An amber note says their flights differ, with the changed slots outlined. Their plan changes when they press the copy button.
Ops Room	Straight away on the day's board.

2.14 Questions and problems

Problem	What to do
The calendar shows a padlock.	You opened another card. Click the LODESTAR logo and pick **Master Planner**. If it is still locked, ask the folder owner for edit rights to Master_Planner.xlsx.
A flight shows **No end time** or **Check time**.	Type a full range such as 0830-1030.
A flight is in the wrong shift.	The start time sets the shift. Correct the start time.
A department cannot see a flight.	Check its crew tag is on (or no tags at all). Then the department presses its copy button.
A squadron event shows **NO CREW**.	Click ALL or the tags of the departments that attend.
A flight does not count in the totals.	The day is set to no flying.
The Crew Matrix does not check a flight.	On Flight Codes, set the code's Crew Matrix column, or make its Mission Type match a mission.
I cannot remove a flight code.	A flight this year still uses it. Switch it off instead.
"The Flights sheet is full".	The file holds 1,000 flights a year. Tell the LODESTAR maintainer.